

HINDUSTAN TIMES

MANDATE SEEKERS
BJP candidate Ujjwal Nikam campaigning in Mumbai, Apr. 30; (left, below) Sena (UBT) candidate Arvind Sawant in Mumbai, May 8

MUMBAI NORTH
Voters: 1.75 mn
Piyush Goyal *BJP*
Vs
Bhushan Patil *Congress*
Incumbent MP: Gopal Shetty, *BJP*

MUMBAI NORTH EAST
Voters: 1.6 mn
Mihir Kotecha *BJP*
Vs
Sanjay Dina Patil *SS(UBT)*
Incumbent MP: Manoj Kotak, *BJP*

THANE
Voters: 2.44 mn
Rajan Vichare *SS(UBT)*
Vs
Naresh Mhaske *SS*
Incumbent MP: Rajan Vichare, *SS(UBT)*

KALYAN
Voters: 2 mn
Dr Shrikant Shinde *SS*
Vs
Vaishali Darekar-Rane *SS(UBT)*
Incumbent MP: Dr Shrikant Shinde, *SS*

BHIWANDI
Voters: 2 mn
Kapil Patil *BJP*
Vs
Suresh 'Balya Mama' Mhatre *NCP(SCP)*
Vs
Nilesh Sambare *Ind*
Incumbent MP: Kapil Patil, *BJP*

PALGHAR
Voters: 2 mn
Dr Hemant Vishnu Sawra *BJP*
Vs
Bharti Kamdi *SS(UBT)*
Vs
Rajesh Patil *BVA*
Incumbent MP: Rajendra Gavit *Shiv Sena*

too. "This Marathi-Muslim combination is very strong," he adds. Another Muslim leader from the MVA explains why the minorities will throw their weight behind them. "The Muslims are willing to support any party that can defeat the BJP. This is being noticed more in the case of the Sena," he says. "In Dongri (a Muslim neighbourhood in Mumbai), even a Shiv Sena flag was enough to spark off a conflagration. Now, Muslim women are going door to door to campaign suo moto." Shaukat Mansuri, a businessman, explains the reason. He says Thackeray's decision to form a government in 2019 with the Congress and NCP, and his attempts to give a "soft" face to the Shiv Sena have helped sway the Muslim voters.

Thackeray loyalists say that the support of sections like Muslims and Buddhist Dalits—followers of Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar who are seen as a social force capable of taking on the Shiv Sena with raw muscle power—may help the Sena (UBT) overcome a depletion in their ranks after the split.

A senior leader of a Republican Party of India (RPI) faction argues that although RPI leaders like Union minister of state Ramdas Athawale and Jogendra Kawade are with the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance, the perception that the Constitution can be amended if the Modi regime returns to power with a vast majority has induced fear among some sections of Dalits. The calls for a 'Hindu Rashtra' have aided the narrative.

Hindutva vs the Marathi Identity

The Mumbai region has always been prone to strong undercurrents of linguistic polarisation, especially between the Marathi and Gujarati speakers. Though monolithic vote transfers are a myth, the working-class Maharashtrians are seen as the traditional voters of the undivided Shiv Sena, while forward castes like the Brahmins support the BJP. The Sena also has pockets of support among the Gujaratis, Marwaris, Hindi speakers and even Muslims.

However, a BJP versus Sena (UBT) battle is taking place in just two seats in the region—Mumbai North East and Palghar.

Parag Alavani, BJP MLA, Vile Parle, says the Sena (UBT)'s core voters were unhappy at its alliance with the Congress and resultant compromise on Hindutva. "Uddhav Thackeray is fighting his own battle and not that of the people... the people will support you [only] if you fight their battle," he explains. Besides the welfare schemes such as for free foodgrains, infrastructure projects and a muscular international position that will fetch the BJP votes, the party, Alavani says, has also penetrated Marathi neighbourhoods and a bulk of its leadership in Mumbai is comprised of Maharashtrians. "Any bulk voting by Muslims will see a counter-mobilisation," he argues. Ashish Shelar, another BJP MLA and the party's Mumbai unit president, claims that Thackeray's "appeasement politics" and "shift of ideology for votes" would cost him the support of the Marathi *manoos*.

For the Mahayuti, the icing on the cake has been the support of the Raj Thackeray-led Maharashtra Navnirman Sena, which may help them get a section of the Marathi vote in Mumbai and neighbouring areas. However, senior Sena (UBT) leader Ravindra Mirlekar claims otherwise. He says there is "anger at the BJP eventually taking on leaders (from the Shiv Sena) who they had charged with corruption in the past." Another senior Sena (UBT) functionary says while the BJP has seen an organic growth in its voters due to erstwhile Sena neighbourhoods being gentrified and the development of a cosmopolitan culture among Maharashtrians, the Shinde Sena's campaign could hit an air pocket if BJP supporters don't turn out to vote for their candidates. Three of the six Lok Sabha seats in Mumbai—Mumbai South, Mumbai South Central and Mumbai North West—and Thane have gone to Shinde's nominees, overriding the BJP's claims.

It is Maharashtra's most complex battle ever, and how Mumbai votes will be crucial in determining how the next chapter in its electoral history will play out. ■